

(V14) Ethical Leadership and Decision-Making Team

Description & Eligibility

This contest will test a team's ability to research and make decisions on an ethical challenge. Teams will submit a research paper on the provided case study, complete an objective test, and create a presentation highlighting proposed solutions to the ethical challenge and lessons learned. This national event will be submitted and judged virtually. Awards will be presented at the National Leadership Conference. Any middle level, secondary or postsecondary contestant may enter this event. A team will consist of 2-4 contestants. There are no restrictions on the number of entries per chapter or per state. **Teams who do not submit an entry following the topic listed below or do not follow the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines will be disqualified.**

Topic

Podcast Adopts Aggressive Digital Marketing Strategy

Gael has just been hired as the new digital marketing director for an online podcast called *The Scholar's Roundtable*, where a panel of hosts breaks down and debates new developments in politics, business, and culture in an educational manner.

While the podcast has been around for over 10 years and enjoyed high viewership initially, *The Scholar's Roundtable* is now barely getting enough views and ad revenue to stay afloat.

To solve this crisis, Gael enacts sweeping changes to the podcast's branding and media strategies. He wants to position the podcast as bold, edgy, and rambunctious—a far cry from the podcast's traditionally dry and straightforward educational approach.

Gael starts posting short clips on TikTok and Instagram Reels that are edited to appear as hot takes and heated debate moments from the show. On X and Facebook, he reposts viral memes and engages with followers on the podcast's official accounts. He even gets approval from the hosts to change the name of the podcast from *The Scholar's Roundtable* to *Politically (In)Correct*.

The revamped digital marketing strategy is a success. *Politically (In)Correct* immediately sees a huge boost in viewership and revenue. Gael wants to push this attention-grabbing branding strategy even further by posting even spicier shorts with AI-generated audio and beefing with competing podcasts on social media. He projects that sticking with this strategy for another two years will triple viewership and bring the podcast the best profits it's ever had.

However, the actual hosts of the podcast are concerned that the show is losing its identity amidst all these changes. They meet with Gael to share their feelings. They worry that the clickbait shorts and social media engagement are not an honest reflection of the podcast, and they don't want to feel pressured to change their show's content.

Gael understands where they come from, but he reminds them that without his digital marketing efforts, the podcast cannot stay profitable. He explains that it might not be pleasant, but an impactful, aggressive digital marketing approach is the best way to go.

Who do you think is right:

- Gael or the podcast hosts?
- Should the podcast continue with a very successful marketing strategy, even if it may not be a very accurate representation of the podcast itself?
- How should large organizations position themselves on social media?
- How can they balance ethics and profits in their digital marketing efforts?
- What is the best path forward?

Competition Notes

- Contest Registration
 - Advisors register contestants for the event using the Membership Registration System, accessible at <https://register.bpa.org>.
 - Click on the "Conferences" tab and then select the "2026 National Virtual Events".
 - There will be a \$20 fee for each team entry (*invoiced during event registration*).
 - Event registration can be purchased with your original invoice or with a new invoice after contestants registration.

- The registration deadline is no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time, on December 1, 2025.
- Contestants participating in the competition must be registered for the event prior to the submission deadline to be eligible.
- Only the team captain should complete the submission.

Technical Pre-submit Specifications

What to Submit at https://upload.bpa.org	Saved File Name(s)	Deadline
Clickable URL to Project Files, Works Cited and BPA Release Form(s) in one combined PDF file	V14-TeamID.pdf	January 15, 2026, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time

Contest Competencies

- Integrity: Demonstrating consistent adherence to ethical principles and values and acting with honesty and fairness in all decisions and actions.
- Accountability: Taking responsibility for one's decisions and actions and being willing to accept the consequences of those choices.
- Transparency: Communicating openly and honestly, providing clear information and explanations for decisions, and ensuring stakeholders understand the rationale behind them.
- Empathy: Understanding and considering the perspectives, feelings, and needs of others when making decisions, and treating people with compassion and respect.
- Objectivity: Making decisions based on facts, evidence, and rational analysis rather than personal biases or self-interest, and avoiding favoritism or unfair treatment.
- Courage: Having the bravery to make difficult decisions that align with ethical principles, even in the face of opposition or potential negative consequences.
- Vision: Developing and articulating a clear ethical vision for the organization or team and aligning decisions and actions with that vision.
- Collaboration: Promoting an inclusive and participatory decision-making process, involving stakeholders and seeking diverse perspectives to ensure fair and informed choices.
- Adaptability: Being open to new information, feedback, and alternative viewpoints, and willing to adjust decisions when necessary to uphold ethical standards.
- Continuous learning: Actively seeking knowledge and understanding of ethical issues, staying informed about emerging trends and best practices, and constantly improving ethical decision-making skills.

Contest Specifications for this Event

- Teams should access MBA Research's free [Ethical Leadership LAP Package](#) for 50+ lesson modules for event preparation.
- All teams will submit a research paper on the proposed case study and complete a 50-question objective test. The technical rubric and average team score will be used to determine the top 20 teams to advance to round two.
- The top 20 teams advancing to round two will receive a case study twist and give a presentation on the proposed solution to the twist, and lessons learned, to a panel of judges.
- The top 10 teams (combined technical, objective average team score, and presentation score) will be invited to the National Leadership Conference.
- The research paper must *not* exceed three (3) pages single-sided (excluding the Title Page, Table of Contents, and Works Cited). The report must follow the Report format in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Any report submitted beyond the maximum number of pages will be *disqualified*.
- Submit the URL to the final Project Files including the research paper, the Works Cited and BPA Release Form(s) in a combined PDF file to <https://upload.bpa.org> no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time, on January 15, 2026. **No changes can be made to the project after the date of submission.**
- Advisors of qualifying teams will be contacted to reserve a time for a videoconference presentation before a panel of judges. The dates and times for presentation reservations will be announced via email notification. Teams will be assigned to sections prior to the preliminary presentation.
- Length of presentation: no more than three (3) minutes for setup, no more than ten (10) minutes for the presentation, and no more than five (5) minutes for judges' questions.

- The top teams with the highest cumulative technical and presentation scores will be invited to attend the National Leadership Conference to be recognized for their outstanding efforts and to participate in the National Showcase.

Common Specifications for all BPA Judged Events

- Team ID is required for all submissions. Materials from non-registered members and/or those missing team ID cannot be accepted.
- The team is responsible for securing a BPA Release Form(s) from any person, including themselves, whose image or work is used in the project.
- The team is responsible for citing all sources, including themselves, on the Works Cited page for any work used on the project. It is the policy of Business Professionals of America to comply with copyright law. The *Style & Reference Manual* contains guidelines for Copyright and/or Fair Use. Contestants will be disqualified for violations of the guidelines.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will *not* be returned and will *not* be available at NLC.

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Technical Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Team followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Team followed Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines.				☐ Y ☐ N
Research Paper did not exceed three (3) pages single-sided (excluding the Title page, Table of Contents and Works Cited).				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to any question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Submission and Formatting (All points or none are awarded by the technical judge)				
Team submitted one (1) combined PDF file containing the Research Paper, Works Cited formatted according to the <i>Style & Reference Manual</i> and BPA Release Form(s).				/10
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-9 points	Meets Expectations 10-15 points	Above Expectations 15-20 points	Points Awarded
Introduction/Summary	Lacks clarity or fails to present key ethical issues.	Clearly summarizes the issue with logical analysis and supporting evidence.	Provides a compelling, well-supported summary that frames the ethical challenge.	/20
Comprehension of Topic	Shows limited understanding or misinterprets ethical concepts.	Demonstrates solid understanding of ethical principles and context.	Shows deep insight and thoughtful engagement with the ethical topic.	/20
Organization & Expansion of Ideas	Ideas are disorganized or lack development.	Ideas are logically structured and supported with relevant evidence.	Ideas are well-developed, insightful, and supported with strong ethical reasoning.	/20
Creativity	Lacks originality or relies on limited perspectives.	Demonstrates creativity with diverse and relevant resources.	Presents a unique and innovative ethical perspective with rich, varied sources.	/20
Overall Effectiveness of Analysis	Analysis is weak or unconvincing.	Analysis is logical and effectively supports conclusions.	Analysis is compelling, well-reasoned, and demonstrates ethical leadership.	/20
Writing Accuracy	Frequent grammar or spelling errors.	Contains some grammar or spelling errors.	Contains very few or no grammar or spelling errors.	/20
TOTAL TECHNICAL POINTS				/130

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Presentation Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Team followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Team followed Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines.				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to either question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-9 points	Meets Expectations 10-15 points	Above Expectations 16-20 points	Points Awarded
Opening & Summary	The introduction is unclear or missing, and the summary lacks relevance or completeness.	The introduction sets the stage appropriately, and the summary covers the main points with adequate clarity.	The introduction is engaging and well-structured, and the summary provides a clear, insightful wrap-up that reinforces key findings.	/20
Content of Presentation	Content is unclear, lacks relevance or depth.	Content is clear, relevant, and adequately developed.	Content is insightful, well-developed, and strongly supports the presentation goals.	/20
Presentation Effectiveness	Delivery is distracting or lacks flow and engagement.	Delivery is smooth with good voice projection, transitions, and presence.	Delivery is polished, engaging, and enhances the impact of the presentation.	/20
Judges Questions	Responses lack depth and fail to demonstrate a comprehensive understanding of the topic.	Some responses lack detail or clarity. The understanding of the topic is partially demonstrated.	Responses are detailed, insightful, and effectively address the judges' questions.	/20
Team Members	At least two original team members were present during the presentation.			/5
Timing	Set-up lasted no longer than three (3) minutes, and the presentation lasted no more than ten (10) minutes.			/10
TOTAL PRESENTATION POINTS				/95

Props and/or additional items shall not be used as a basis for scoring.

PRESENTATION WILL BE STOPPED AT 10 MINUTES